



mysterious entity called “The Zone.” At this point, nothing is known about its origins, its purpose, or its nature except that anything that goes into The Zone does not come out again, and that it has been sealed off by the authorities, and is guarded by military police.

What it is that lurks in The Zone is something Tarkovsky has no desire to reveal. As the title of *Sculpting in Time* suggests, he is interested in time, something he uses a lot of—his movie clocks in at around the three-hour mark. It begins on the outskirts of the story, where the title character (played by Aleksandr Kaydanovsky) is getting ready for work. The word “stalker” suggests menace, but in this near-future world, a Stalker is both a thief who tries to smuggle artifacts out of The Zone and a guide who is willing to take others in.

Entering The Zone

The Stalker’s world is poor and run-down, a fact reflected in the sepia cinematography used in the

first portion of the movie, but his wife still begs him not to go into The Zone and is afraid for his safety. He brushes away her concerns and heads off to meet his two clients, known simply as the Writer and the Professor, who want to travel to The Zone, hearing that it has strange and possibly magical powers.

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The quintessence of Tarkovsky’s spaces, the Zone is where one goes to see one’s innermost desires. It is, in short, the cinema.

Robert Bird

Andrei Tarkovsky:

Elements of Cinema, 2008

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The Stalker lies injured as the men first enter The Zone. As they venture into the unknown, to the sound of dripping water, the Stalker describes it as “the quietest place in the world.”

When the trio arrive at The Zone, the movie suddenly switches from sepia into the colors of the modern world: “We are home,” says the Stalker. But the men have not yet reached their ultimate destination. Within The Zone, where the normal practicalities of life no longer apply and lots of strange, inexplicable phenomena seem to occur, there is a place called The Room. When they find it, the Stalker tells them, with excitement and awe, “Your most cherished desire will come true here...” adding, “The desire that has made you suffer most.”

However, it is not The Room itself that concerns Tarkovsky but his characters’ arrival at its threshold. What is it that they really want? And what will they find inside? At this point, *Stalker* mutes its thriller aspect and becomes a